ABCC Past Editions and Case Clients — Practice Dossier

Prepared for the ABCC 2027 team (4 Masters students + coach) | Status: July 2026

This dossier reconstructs the history of the Asper Business Case Competition (ABCC) — founded in 2023 as the Asper Leadership Case Competition (ALCC) at the University of Manitoba's I.H. Asper School of Business — and profiles every known case client in enough depth to **re-crack the past cases as timed practice runs**. Part I covers each edition; Part II profiles each client, ending with a *Re-crack brief* (task restatement, guiding questions, what a winning answer likely needed); Part III distils patterns for 2027. Official case PDFs are linked under Sources; six are included in this repository under `01-competition/past-case-pdfs/`.

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Part I — The five editions

At a glance

Edition	Dates	Field	Format	Champion	Rest of podium
ALCC 2023 (1st)	Feb 23–25, 2023	8 Canadian graduate teams	2 rounds, 50/50	Not publicly documented	Asper 2nd; 3rd unknown
ABCC 2024 (2nd)	Feb 21–24, 2024	9 teams	3 rounds, 25/30/45	Asper ("Stellaris Consulting")	Haskayne 2nd, DeGroote 3rd
ABCC 2025 (3rd)	Feb 19–23, 2025	9 teams	3 rounds, 25/30/45	Memorial University	John Molson 2nd, DeGroote 3rd
ABCC 2026 (4th)	Feb 18–21, 2026	9 teams, first international entrant	3 rounds, 25/30/45	Babeș-Bolyai University (Romania)	DeGroote 2nd, HEC Montréal 3rd, John Molson 4th
ABCC 2027 (5th)	Feb 18–22, 2027	TBA	3 rounds, 25/30/45	—	—

All editions share two structural constants: every case client is a **Manitoba/Winnipeg organization**, and

teams compete anonymously as **fictional consulting firms** (revealing your school to judges is prohibited).

ALCC 2023 — the inaugural "Leadership" edition

- **Dates/venues:** February 23–25, 2023, Winnipeg — events at Manitoba Hydro's downtown HQ, The Forks, Festival du Voyageur and the Asper School.
- **Field (8):** Asper, Beedie (SFU), DeGroote (McMaster), Haskayne (Calgary), HEC Montréal, John Molson (Concordia), Rotman (Toronto), Telfer (Ottawa).
- **Format:** two rounds, each weighted 50% — prepared case (two weeks' prep, 25 min + 15 Q&A) and traditional case (3-hour crack, 20 + 10); top three to finals (20 + 15). Prizes: $5,000 / $3,000 / $1,000.
- **Cases:** both rounds used one client, **Manitoba Hydro**, under a leadership theme tied to "Strategy 2040": *Developing & Leading a Change-Ready Organization* (prepared) and *Leading a Change in Narrative* (traditional; customer trust and rate-increase support).
- **Podium:** champion and third place were never published (verified absence — no recap article exists). Only documented placement: **Asper's home team finished 2nd**. Scale: 24 competitors, 25 judges.

ABCC 2024 — rebrand and the boardroom round

- **Dates:** February 21–24, 2024. Renamed the Asper *Business* Case Competition; expanded to three rounds.
- **Field (9):** Asper, Beedie, DeGroote, Haskayne, HEC Montréal, John Molson, **Levene (U Regina, new)**, **Ted Rogers (TMU, new)**, Telfer. Rotman did not return.
- **Rounds:** Prepared 25% — **WAG-Qaumajuq** (admission models making gallery entry free; presented on site at the gallery). Boardroom 30%, new format (4-hour prep, 3-minute pitch on one executive-summary slide, 22 minutes of seated judge discussion) — **IJL** (national expansion). Traditional 45% — **StandardAero** (attracting aviation talent), with public finals.
- **Podium:** 1st **Asper** ("Stellaris Consulting"); 2nd **Haskayne**; 3rd **DeGroote**. U Regina's team won the boardroom round outright. Scale: 36 competitors, 50 judges.

ABCC 2025 — Memorial's win

- **Dates:** February 19–23, 2025. Day 1 presentations at the Manitoba Museum; days 2–3 at the Drake Centre.
- **Field (9):** Asper, Beedie, DeGroote, HEC Montréal, **Ivey (new)**, John Molson, Levene, **Memorial (new)**, Telfer (Haskayne and Ted Rogers out).
- **Rounds:** Prepared — **The Manitoba Museum** (financially sustainable return of blockbuster exhibitions). Boardroom — **AROW Global** (the next $10M+ product/market). Traditional — **People Corporation** (rebuild trust in the SpringBoard platform).
- **Podium:** 1st **Memorial University**; 2nd **John Molson**; 3rd **DeGroote**. Scale: 36 competitors, 60+ judges.

ABCC 2026 — first international field

- **Dates:** February 18–21, 2026. "Case village" at the Delta hotel downtown; gala at Marshall McLuhan Hall.
- **Field (9):** first-ever international team, **Babeș-Bolyai University (Cluj-Napoca, Romania)**; confirmed others: Asper, Beedie, DeGroote, HEC Montréal, John Molson (full nine-team list unpublished).
- **Rounds:** Prepared — **Jazz Winnipeg** (fix a structural ~$50,000 annual deficit; "bold transformation vs. gradual adaptation"). Boardroom — **Coal & Canary** (elevate the brand from premium to high-end luxury). Traditional — **Access Credit Union** (digital banking to engage Gen Z and Gen Alpha).
- **Podium:** 1st **Babeș-Bolyai** — the only undefeated team, winning all three qualifying rounds and the final unanimously (CAD $5,000 + trophy); 2nd **DeGroote**; 3rd **HEC Montréal**; 4th John Molson. Scale: 35 competitors, 50 judges.

ABCC 2027 — what we are entering

February 18–22, 2027; teams of four graduate students; hotel Delta Winnipeg; venue the Drake Centre (the Asper School of Business building) — daily agenda and round-to-day mapping still TBA. Format carried over: Prepared 25% (25 + 15), Boardroom 30% (3-minute pitch + 22-minute discussion, one slide plus a one-page black-and-white judge brief), Traditional 45% (20 + 10); top three re-present frozen decks to a fresh judge panel (20 + 15). Notable rules: finalists' faculty advisors barred from contact until after presenting; maximum four laptops, no phones or smartwatches; ties broken by performance in the highest-weighted rounds.

Part II — Client profiles and re-crack briefs

Ordered by recency (2026 → 2023). Each profile is written so the case can be re-cracked without the original PDF, though the PDFs — where public — are the primary practice documents.

1. Jazz Winnipeg — 2026 Prepared Case

"Jazz Winnipeg at a Crossroads: Accessibility, Culture, and Viability in the Changing Entertainment Industry"

A charitable non-profit arts presenter in Winnipeg's Exchange District, "promoting the art of jazz and creative music through concert presentations and community engagement." Its flagship is the **TD Winnipeg International Jazz Festival** (annual since 1989; the 2026 edition was the 35th, ~50 artists from 8 countries), combining a free outdoor stage in Old Market Square with ticketed venues; year-round activity includes concert series, workshops, and community programs. The organization is tiny — Executive Director **Angela Heck**, an artistic director, a couple of staff, heavy volunteer reliance — with a classic arts-non-profit revenue mix: ticket sales, the TD title sponsorship and other corporate sponsors, public grants (Canadian Heritage, Manitoba Arts Council, Winnipeg Arts Council), and donations. Strategic pressures: an aging core jazz audience, post-pandemic live-music economics, competition for summer audiences and donor dollars (Folk Festival, Fringe, Festival du Voyageur), and a small home market (metro Winnipeg < 850,000).

Re-crack brief. As consultants to ED Angela Heck, resolve a structural annual deficit of roughly $50,000 by pitching a "radical new idea," explicitly weighing bold transformation against gradual adaptation — a strategy that restores financial viability while honouring the organization's cultural mandate and its grant and sponsor relationships. Guiding questions: (1) Where can a three-person charity realistically find $50k+ of new annual contribution margin — programming, pricing, venues, sponsorship, philanthropy, or costs — and in what mix? (2) Which audience segments offer growth, and which formats (club nights, crossover acts, streaming, education) reach them without alienating the jazz core that legitimizes the grants? (3) What would "bold transformation" concretely be — a year-round venue, a rebrand beyond "jazz," a second festival property — and what risk does it pose to TD and public funders? (4) What have comparable presenters done to diversify revenue, and with what results? (5) What can this organization's capacity credibly execute in 24 months? (6) How do you measure success beyond break-even (audience age, donor conversion, revenue per event)? **A winning answer likely needed** one signature move — not a laundry list — with a quantified bridge from today's deficit to a modest surplus, benchmarked against real peer organizations, staged to fit a volunteer-dependent team, and framed to reassure rather than frighten funders.

2. Coal & Canary Candle Company — 2026 Boardroom Case

"Coal & Canary: Shifting from Premium to High-End Luxury"

A Winnipeg premium candle maker founded in **2014** by graphic designer **Amanda Buhse** and **Tom Jansen** with about $300 of startup capital. Products: hand-poured soy/vegetable-wax candles with wooden wicks, 45–50-hour burn, ~30 SKUs with cheeky millennial names ("Chunky Knit Sweater" is the perennial bestseller), priced ~US$28 for 8 oz — deliberately "attainable luxury" for 25–35-year-old women. Roughly **15 employees**; production in a Border Street warehouse; a flagship store at The Forks Market; e-commerce; candle-making classes and corporate/custom lines. Distribution is broad for an indie brand: **wholesale to 200–250+ stockists across Canada and the US, plus Sephora** (which discovered the brand on Instagram); early buzz came from Grammy and Oscar gift bags. Last public revenue figure: ~C$1M (2018), then doubling year-over-year. The competitive frame stretches from mass (Bath & Body Works, Yankee) past fellow artisans up to true luxury (Diptyque at ~C$90+, Jo Malone, Byredo) — and that gap is the case.

Re-crack brief. In boardroom format (4-hour prep, one slide, one-page black-and-white brief, 3-minute pitch, 22 minutes of grilling), advise the founders on how to elevate Coal & Canary from a premium brand to a genuine high-end luxury brand. Guiding questions: (1) What actually codes as "luxury" in home fragrance — price architecture, scarcity, materials, packaging, service ritual, provenance story — and which codes can this company credibly adopt? (2) Full repositioning or a two-tier architecture (accessible core plus an elevated flagship line)? (3) What happens to 200+ wholesale doors and Sephora — prune, keep, or reframe — given that ubiquity is the enemy of luxury? (4) Can "hand-poured in Winnipeg" carry a luxury narrative, and how? (5) What pricing, margins, and volumes make the move financially sensible for 15 people and one warehouse? (6) Which attack will the judges lead with — brand stretch, cannibalization, capacity — and what is your pre-built answer? **A winning answer likely needed** a sharp, defensible thesis (most plausibly a limited-edition luxury line with curated channels and storytelling, protecting the existing cash engine), expressed cleanly on

one slide, with the channel trade-off argued before the judges could raise it. The boardroom round rewards poise under interrogation more than analytical breadth.

3. Access Credit Union — 2026 Traditional Case

"Access Credit Union: Designing Digital Banking"

Manitoba's largest credit union and one of Canada's largest: **~$14.1B in assets, 208,000+ members, 925+ employees, ~50 branches**. Built through relentless mergers: rural roots in the 1930s–40s (Altona, Winkler), the Access formation in 2009, then Crosstown Civic (2021), Noventis + Sunova (2022), Casera + Carpathia (2023). A member-owned full-service co-operative: personal and business banking, a major agricultural lending franchise, wealth management (Credential/Qtrade/Aviso), insurance, profit-sharing and community reinvestment. Strategic squeeze: Big-5 digital offerings, fintechs and neobanks (Wealthsimple, EQ, Neo) pulling young Canadians away, an aging rural member base, and fellow Manitoba credit unions (Steinbach, Assiniboine, Cambrian, Fusion) competing at home. Post-case developments confirm the diagnosis: a leadership transition to CEO **Myrna Wiebe**, and 2026 announcements of **six branch consolidations** (citing lower in-branch traffic and rising mobile adoption) alongside one new Winnipeg branch.

Re-crack brief. In a three-hour crack, advise Access on innovating its services and digital banking to engage young people — Gen Z and Gen Alpha — and reverse youth attrition. Guiding questions: (1) Which youth segments matter most (rural teens in farm-succession families, urban students, first-job Gen Z), and how do their jobs-to-be-done differ from what a Big-5 app or Wealthsimple offers? (2) What product-and-onboarding bundle closes the gap fastest — instant digital account opening, no-fee youth accounts, gamified saving, financial-literacy content, first credit products? (3) How does the co-operative identity (ownership, profit-sharing, community roots) become a genuine differentiator for a generation that values authenticity, rather than jargon? (4) How do you serve digital-first youth while an aging rural base still depends on branches — what does the consolidation trend permit? (5) What are the economics — acquisition cost versus lifetime value as young members grow into mortgages, ag loans, and wealth products? (6) What is the phased roadmap and KPI set a board could approve? **A winning answer likely needed** segment-led design rather than a generic "build an app" answer, one memorable hook (e.g., real ownership benefits for young members), honest treatment of the rural/branch tension, and quantified member-acquisition targets.

4. The Manitoba Museum — 2025 Prepared Case

"The Manitoba Museum: Bringing the World Home"

Manitoba's largest museum (human and natural history, Planetarium, Science Gallery); an independent not-for-profit charity, not a provincial agency. **~300,000 visitors/year**, including ~100,000 schoolchildren — "the largest classroom in the province." Revenue mix per the case: a **provincial operating grant equal to 51% of revenue, flat since 2008** (about 40% real-terms erosion); admissions/memberships/programs 25%; fundraising 12%; rentals 4%; shop 2%. The problem: Alloway Hall (expanded in 2017 with public money, which effectively obliges blockbuster programming) hosts four-month travelling exhibitions costing **$400–600k upfront — and every temporary exhibition from 2013 to 2022 lost money** (2022's "Ultimate Dinosaurs": 23,945 visitors vs. 45,000 projected, ~$300k loss, undercut by two competing dinosaur events in the same city). Blockbusters also displace lucrative wedding and event rentals.

Re-crack brief. As consultants to CEO Dorota Blumczyńska for her Board of Governors, deliver a financially sustainable plan to bring blockbuster exhibitions back — covering exhibition timing, the pricing model (surcharge vs. included in admission), required attendance, how to capitalize on the traffic, and benchmarks from peer museums. Guiding questions: (1) What attendance × price combination makes a $500k show break even, and how sensitive is that model? (2) Surcharge or bundled pricing — what do peer museums do, and what fits a heavily grant-funded charity with an accessibility mandate? (3) How can risk be shared — sponsorship, co-productions, touring consortia, government top-ups? (4) How should the calendar protect rental revenue? (5) How is one-time blockbuster traffic converted into memberships, donations, and repeat visits? (6) Which exhibition themes fit Winnipeg and avoid head-on competition? **A winning answer likely needed** a genuine break-even model presented transparently, a clear pricing recommendation with benchmark support, a risk-sharing structure that caps downside, and a conversion funnel — all tied back to the museum's strategic plan.

5. AROW Global — 2025 Boardroom Case

"AROW Global: Looking for the Next Big Idea"

Established 1965; designs and manufactures **window systems and driver protection systems (DPS) for transit buses** and heavy-duty vehicles, plus custom metal fabrication. Plants in Winnipeg and Mosinee, Wisconsin; owns the Techni-Glass factory in Tennessee. Owned by Anvil Management within Winnipeg's Price group; ~530 employees across the three sites. Market position is dominant but saturated: **~90% share in configurable DPS**, ~80% in its other core line; customers include New Flyer/NFI and BC Transit; competitors Ricon (Wabtec) and, prospectively, Lippert. After a DPS-driven boom, growth has gone **flat** — hence the ask. The case sets a hard screen: a new product/sector/market with **≥$10M annual revenue** (ideally a $30–40M market), **40% margin, cash-flow positive within 3 years, $4–5M year-one investment**; preferences: blue-ocean B2B, truck/rail-shippable, no smart glass, no bus shelters, nothing structurally complex.

Re-crack brief. In boardroom format, recommend the next big idea and the plan to validate it. Guiding questions: (1) Which adjacent B2B niches pass the numeric screen — think agricultural/construction cab glazing, rail or marine windows, specialty vehicle retrofits, security glazing, modular enclosures? (2) Which of AROW's capabilities (glass, aluminum extrusion, stamping, welding, assembly, transit OEM relationships) transfer, and what must be bought or built? (3) How do you stay "blue ocean" while respecting the explicit no-gos? (4) What year-one validation plan (pilot customers, LOIs, prototypes) proves demand before the $4–5M is fully committed? (5) How would incumbents respond? (6) Does your one-page brief survive black-and-white printing and a 22-minute grilling? **A winning answer likely needed** *one* rigorously screened opportunity — not a menu — with a capability-fit argument, arithmetic that visibly satisfies every stated constraint, and a staged go/no-go validation plan.

6. People Corporation — 2025 Traditional Case

"People Corporation: Rebuilding Trust"

Founded 2007, HQ Winnipeg; a Canadian **group benefits, group retirement, and HR services** firm with 60+ offices and 2,500+ employees; acquired by **Goldman Sachs** Merchant Banking in December 2020 for **C$1.13B**; 2024 revenue above $500M in a $59.7B Canadian group-benefits market dominated by three insurers (People Corp share <10%). Distribution is split roughly 50/50 between 200+ direct consultants and independent third-party advisors. The problem: **SpringBoard**, the in-house benefits-administration platform, was launched ~5 years earlier — mandatory, buggy, painful — and although it now works well (95–97% client retention once onboarded), the sales channels still distrust it; there is no dedicated internal support team, and an acquired competitor product (Benefits by Design) overlaps at the small-client end. COO **Manny Atwal** frames it memorably: "You're not selling a widget; you're selling your experience and reputation."

Re-crack brief. In a three-hour crack, tell Atwal how to get clients onto SpringBoard, deliver faster quotes, speed up onboarding — and above all rebuild SpringBoard's reputation with the direct sales force and third-party agents. Guiding questions: (1) Is today's problem product quality or organizational memory — and what evidence separates the two? (2) Do direct consultants and independent agents need different trust-repair treatments (incentives, guarantees, support)? (3) What internal infrastructure (dedicated support team, SLAs, champion program, migration playbooks) do competitors have that People Corp lacks? (4) Should SpringBoard stay mandatory for new clients, and how do BBD overlaps get resolved? (5) What does a credible relaunch look like — pilot references, quote-turnaround targets, possibly a rebrand? (6) Which metrics prove trust is returning (adoption, NPS, onboarding time, retention)? **A winning answer likely needed** a change-management program that fixes the internal audience first and the market second, sequenced as a visible relaunch with measurable commitments — recognizing this as a trust problem wearing a technology costume.

7. WAG-Qaumajuq (Winnipeg Art Gallery) — 2024 Prepared Case

"Winnipeg Art Gallery-Qaumajuq: A Strategy for the Future"

One of Canada's oldest civic art galleries (1912), transformed in March 2021 by **Qaumajuq** — a ~$65M, Michael Maltzan-designed museum holding the **world's largest public collection of contemporary Inuit art** (~14,000 pieces, displayed in a three-storey glass "Visible Vault"), governed with an Indigenous Advisory Circle and a strong reconciliation mandate. A non-profit charity funded by admissions, memberships, grants, donors, and events; it had already piloted free youth and Indigenous memberships and free-admission days.

The case (sponsored by the James W. Burns Leadership Institute) asked teams to **pitch admission models that would make entry free for the community** — permanently and sustainably.

Re-crack brief. Design a financially viable free-admission model for WAG-Qaumajuq. Guiding questions: (1) How much revenue does paid admission actually contribute, and what precisely must replace it? (2) Which models map to Winnipeg — corporate-sponsored free days, an endowed free-entry fund, government top-up, pay-what-you-can, membership upsell (UK national museums are the classic benchmark)? (3) How does free entry advance the reconciliation and community mandate, and how is that argued to sponsors as naming-rights value? (4) Which second-order revenues (memberships, retail, café, events, philanthropy inspired by higher footfall) grow when the doors are free? (5) What phasing and metrics de-risk the transition? **A winning answer likely needed** a named funding mechanism with real numbers — who pays, how much, in what structure — plus evidence from peer institutions that attendance gains translate into mission and money, not just cost.

8. Independent Jewellers Ltd (IJL Since 1937) — 2024 Boardroom Case

"Independent Jewellers Ltd: In Pursuit of National Expansion"

A third-generation family luxury jeweller founded 1937 in Winnipeg, run since 2013 by brothers **Jeremy and Jonathan Epp** (both Asper graduates). One rebuilt 3,500 sq ft showroom, ~15 staff (in-house gemologist, goldsmith, appraiser), tagline "a tradition of trust." Authorized retailer for **Rolex — the only one in Winnipeg** — plus Omega, IWC, TAG Heuer, and jewellery brands. Shopify e-commerce since 2019 produced ~$315–417k/year, with about half of orders (two-thirds of online revenue) from outside Winnipeg — but **Rolex and other watch brands prohibit online sales**, capping the web assortment. Context: Canadian luxury retail is consolidating into Vancouver/Toronto/Montreal/Calgary "clusters of luxury"; Birks closed its 120-year-old downtown Winnipeg store in 2023.

Re-crack brief. In boardroom format, deliver (a) a national-expansion strategy (which cities/regions, online vs. bricks-and-mortar mix, and the sustainable advantage), (b) a local-to-national brand-awareness strategy, and (c) a first-stage pilot on a **$100,000 budget** with activities, timeline, KPIs, and risk mitigation. Guiding questions: (1) What can "national" credibly mean for a 15-person firm when its marquee brand cannot be sold online — e-commerce of unrestricted categories, clienteling and concierge sales, pop-ups, or a store in a luxury cluster? (2) What does the existing out-of-province online demand reveal? (3) What is the transferable advantage — heritage, trust, custom work, watch allocation relationships? (4) What single $100k pilot buys the most learning per dollar? (5) How do you avoid endangering the Rolex relationship or cannibalizing the home store? **A winning answer likely needed** a focused thesis (most plausibly digital/clienteling-led national growth of unrestricted categories, with targeted physical presence later), a genuinely concrete pilot with KPIs, and explicit handling of the brand-partner constraint rather than wishing it away.

9. StandardAero — 2024 Traditional Case

"StandardAero: Hiring for the Future"

One of the world's largest independent aircraft-engine **MRO** (maintenance, repair, overhaul) providers, rooted in Winnipeg's Standard Machine Works (1911). HQ is now Scottsdale, Arizona, but Winnipeg remains a flagship site (~1,200 employees at peak; home of GE Aviation's $50M engine test and R&D centre). ~7,000+ employees globally; after successive private-equity owners, it IPO'd on the NYSE in October 2024 (SARO, ~$10.4B valuation; FY2024 revenue ~$5.2B). The case theme: the acute **skilled-trades shortage** — aircraft maintenance engineers and technicians — in a Winnipeg aerospace cluster where StandardAero competes for people with Magellan, Boeing Winnipeg, and OEM service arms.

Re-crack brief. In a three-hour crack, develop strategies for attracting top aviation talent to StandardAero. Guiding questions: (1) Which talent pools give the best yield — new AME graduates, mid-career technicians, internationally trained workers via immigration pathways, adjacent trades, veterans? (2) What employer value proposition differentiates an independent MRO from OEMs and airlines? (3) What is the right split between pipeline-building (apprenticeships, college partnerships, schools outreach) and retention (pay progression, certification support, culture)? (4) How large is the gap, and what does an unfilled position cost? (5) What can be piloted in Winnipeg and scaled globally? **A winning answer likely needed** a segmented talent strategy with a costed pipeline program and an employer-brand core — specific to aviation trades, not generic HR boilerplate.

10. Manitoba Hydro — 2023 Prepared and Traditional Cases

"Developing & Leading a Change-Ready Organization" / "Leading a Change in Narrative"

Manitoba's provincial Crown utility: sole electricity provider and principal gas distributor; 97% renewable generation; ~600,000 electricity and 290,000 gas customers; ~5,400 employees, ~80% unionized; heavy debt (≈86% debt ratio) after the Keeyask and Bipole III megaprojects; rates regulated by the Public Utilities Board; ~$18B of capital needs over 20 years. Case-era context: "Strategy 2040" and the "three Ds" (decarbonization, decentralization, digitalization), against a culture marked by change fatigue — 2017 voluntary departures, a 2020 layoff scare, 2021–22 strikes, an aging workforce.

Re-crack brief (two tasks). *Prepared:* as advisors to the CEO, prepare the organization's people and culture to execute Strategy 2040 — empowerment, agility, trust, breaking silos — explicitly recommending on **change capacity, not the strategy itself**. *Traditional:* as advisors to the VP Customer Solutions & Experience, build customer trust and loyalty across four challenges: winning public support for rate increases, generating customer insight, retaining "omnisumers" who could self-generate, and meeting digital-era service expectations — all within Crown-corporation and regulatory constraints. Guiding questions: (1) Which change-management levers fit a unionized, change-fatigued utility (leadership development, structural de-siloing, participation mechanisms, communication cadence)? (2) How is change-readiness measured? (3) How does a monopoly earn *support* for an $18B investment program — what mix of transparency, service improvement, and narrative? (4) What does loyalty mean when customers cannot switch but can defect via rooftop solar? (5) Which digital-experience moves build trust fastest? **A winning answer likely needed** discipline about the brief (culture, not strategy critique, in round one) and, in round two, a trust-and-communications program that connects tangible service improvements to the rate-case narrative.

Part III — Patterns to exploit for 2027

1. **The client formula is stable.** Prepared round: an arts/culture non-profit with a revenue-sustainability problem (WAG '24 → Manitoba Museum '25 → Jazz Winnipeg '26). Boardroom round: an owner-led local consumer or family business facing a growth/positioning choice (IJL '24 → AROW '25 → Coal & Canary '26). Traditional round: a large Manitoba-rooted enterprise with a trust, talent, or digital-engagement challenge (StandardAero '24 → People Corp '25 → Access CU '26). Expect ABCC 2027 to follow the template — scanning Winnipeg's non-profit arts scene and prominent local companies before February is rational preparation.
2. **Recurring themes:** financial sustainability for grant-dependent non-profits; growing beyond a small home market; brand elevation; rebuilding trust (internal, customer, member); engaging youth and talent; digital transition. Build reusable frameworks and benchmark libraries for each.
3. **Case craft:** all cases are supervised by Judy Jayasuriya (Asper Experiential Learning), mix public information with executive interviews and real financial appendices, ban contacting the client, and encourage outside research. Expect hard numbers in the appendices — winning teams use them.
4. **Boardroom mechanics matter:** judges receive the one-page black-and-white brief ~10 minutes before you enter; 3 minutes protected, then 22 minutes of interrogation. Practice the artifact (one slide + one-pager) and the grilling separately.
5. **Practice plan:** re-crack the 2025 set under real time pressure (all three PDFs are public), then the 2023 Hydro pair, then IJL; use this dossier's profiles to simulate the 2024 WAG/StandardAero and 2026 rounds where PDFs are thinner. Note that Babeș-Bolyai won 2026 by winning *every* round — consistency across all three formats, not one brilliant final, is the winning profile.

Sources

Official competition pages and recaps

- ABCC official page: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/asper-business-case-competition · ALCC 2023 page: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/asper-leadership-case-competition
- Past cases hub: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/student-experience/case-competitions
- 2023 announcement; 2024 and 2025 UM Today recaps (via Wayback): https://news.umanitoba.ca/first-ever-asper-leadership-case-competition-kicks-off-in-february/ · https://news.umanitoba.ca/second-annual-asper-business-case-competition-spotlights-manitoba-businesses/ · https://news.umanitoba.ca/when-the-classroom-becomes-a-boardroom-a-recap-of-the-2025-asper-business-case-competition/

- 2026 recap: https://umtoday.ca/stories/forging-worldwide-relationships-2026-asper-business-case-competition
- Podium corroboration: https://www.uregina.ca/business-administration/news/2024/success-asper-case-competition.html · https://gazette.mun.ca/student-life/high-note/ · https://ager-pres.ro/comunicate/2026/02/24/comunicat-de-presa—universitatea-babes-bolyai-din-cluj-napoca–1531333 · https://www.concordia.ca/jmsb/services/competitions/wins.html · https://www.hec.ca/en/news/2026/mba-team-places-3rd-at-the-asper-business-case-competition

Case PDFs (primary practice documents)

- 2023 Manitoba Hydro (prepared / traditional): https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2024-08/alcc-2023-prepared-case-final.pdf · https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2024-08/alcc-2023-traditional-case-final-2.pdf
- 2024 WAG-Qaumajuq / IJL / StandardAero: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2024-08/abcc-case-1.pdf · https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2024-09/abcc-24_case-2.pdf · https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2024-08/abcc-24_case-3-.pdf
- 2025 Manitoba Museum / AROW / People Corp: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2025-03/abcc-25_case-1.pdf · https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2025-03/abcc-25_case-2.pdf · https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2025-03/abcc-25_case-3.pdf
- 2026 Jazz Winnipeg / Coal & Canary: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2026-05/abcc-2026_-prepared-case.pdf · https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2026-05/abcc-2026_boardroom-case_-final.pdf · Access CU: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2026-04/abcc-2026_traditional-case-final.pdf
- Copies in this repository (`01-competition/past-case-pdfs/`, official Asper publications, © University of Manitoba — internal team practice only, do not redistribute): `alcc2023_prepared_manitoba-hydro.pdf`, `alcc2023_traditional_manitoba-hydro.pdf`, `abcc2024_boardroom_independent-jewellers.pdf`, `abcc2025_prepared_manitoba-museum.pdf`, `abcc2025_boardroom_arow-global.pdf`, `abcc2025_traditional_people-corporation.pdf`. Not mirrored (use the URLs above): 2024 case 1 (WAG) and case 3 (StandardAero), all three 2026 cases.

Event guides and reports

- ALCC23 guide: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2023-02/ALCC23-CompetitionGuide-Final_DIGITAL.pdf · ABCC24 guide: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2024-02/ABCC24-EventGuide-Web-FNL.pdf · ABCC25 guide: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2025-01/abcc25-eventguide.pdf
- Impact reports 2022-23 / 2023-24: https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2023-05/CaseComps-AnnualReport2023-FNL-Web.pdf · https://umanitoba.ca/asper/sites/asper/files/2024-04/casecomps-impactreport2024-web.pdf

Client background

- Jazz Winnipeg: https://www.jazzwinnipeg.com/about · https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Winnipeg_International_Jazz_Festival · https://umfm.com/news/jazz-winnipeg-announces-2026-td-winnipeg-international-jass-festival-line-up
- Coal & Canary: https://www.beautyindependent.com/cheeky-millennial-candle-brand-coal-and-canary-new-sephora-entrant/ · https://www.winnipeg-chamber.com/150-member-stories-coal-and-canary/ · https://www.coalandcanary.com/
- Access Credit Union: https://www.accesscu.ca/en/about · https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Access_Credit_Union · https://www.accesscu.ca/en/news/access-cu-announces-branch-consolidations-and-new-winnipeg-location
- Manitoba Museum: https://manitobamuseum.ca/ (annual reports under /our-mission/annual-reports/)
- AROW Global ownership context: https://anvilmanagement.ca/ · https://manitoba-inc.ca/time-to-shine-celebrating-75-years-of-growth-at-price-industries/
- People Corporation: https://www.theglobeandmail.com/business/article-winnipegs-people-corp-sold-for-113-billion-to-goldman-sachs/
- WAG-Qaumajuq: https://www.wag.ca/about/qaumajuq/ · https://www.wag.ca/media/wag-to-pilot-free-affordable-membership-for-qaumajuqs-inaugural-year/
- IJL: https://ijl.ca/ · https://www.jewellerybusiness.com/features/shaking-the-foundations-independent-jewellers-quest-to-build-on-its-legacy/

- StandardAero: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/StandardAero · https://ir.standardaero.com/
- Manitoba Hydro: https://www.hydro.mb.ca/ · https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/manitoba/manitoba-hydro-new-ceo-1.7258441

Known gaps: the ALCC 2023 champion and third place were never published; the full 2026 nine-team list is unconfirmed; prize amounts are documented only for 2023 (full scale) and 2026 (first place, $5,000); Coal & Canary's current revenue is private.